

CXE-01 | FREE PREVIEW

Engineering the Customer Experience

FREE PREVIEW EDITION • Theory, practice and certification for contact-service teams

PARTICIPANT MANUAL (PREVIEW) • Agent Track + Leader Track

Organization / Department: _____

Participant name: _____

Employee ID / Team: _____

Facilitator: _____

Dates: _____

Customer Experience Engineering Certification Program • v1.0, September 2026 • Developed by Juan Carlos Munguia, Continuous Improvement Consulting
Aligned with COPC CX Standard R8.0 (2026) principles. COPC is a trademark of COPC Inc.; this program is independent and not endorsed by COPC Inc. or Gartner.

This is a free preview

This **free preview** shows the structure and about 30% of the Customer Experience Engineering Participant Manual. The full program includes every skill, tool, script, updated 2024-2026 data, the leader track, and four certification assessments (theory + role plays + live interactions).

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Contents

How to use this manual . . . 5

Program overview and agenda . . . 6

1.1 An effective and emerging frontline skill . . . 7

1.2 Why it matters more than ever . . . 7

1.3 Reducing customer effort: a goal with great value . . . 8

1.4 What "effort" really means . . . 10

1.5 It goes beyond being nice . . . 11

1.6 Traditional soft skills vs. experience engineering . . . 11

1.7 Relationship focus vs. outcome focus . . . 12

1.8 The framework: strategy and seven skills . . . 12

1.9 How does this benefit me? . . . 13

1.10 Where effort sits in the Kano model . . . 14

Skill 1: Active listening . . . 17

Skill 2: Purposeful small talk . . . 19

Skill 3: Positive language . . . 22

Skill 4: Advocacy . . . 26

Skill 5: Alternative positioning . . . 27

Skill 6: Understanding my dominant personality style . . . 30

Skill 7: Flexing to others' personalities . . . 34

5.1 What the 2025-2026 data says . . . 38

5.2 The seven skills after a failed bot . . . 39

5.3 Digital-channel adaptations . . . 39

6.1 The parallel process . . . 40

6.2 The seven skills, leader version . . . 42

6.3 The Experience-Engineered Coaching Conversation (5 steps) . . . 42

6.4 Monitoring, calibration and coaching aligned with COPC R8.0 . . . 43

6.5 Measuring effort: the leader's dashboard . . . 45

6.6 Building the culture: team rituals . . . 46

Summary . . . 48

My first three steps . . . 48

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Appendix A. Phrasebook: say this, not that 49

Appendix B. Main contact drivers and KPIs 49

Appendix C. Glossary 50

Appendix D. Program documents and key references 50

Get the full certification program 52

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How to use this manual

This manual is the core reading and workbook for the **Customer Experience Engineering (CXE)** internal certification. It is written for a contact-service operation of any size: an in-house customer service department, a shared-service center, or an outsourced (BPO) program. The organization used in examples, **ACME Customer Care Center**, is fictitious. Replace it with your own organization, teams and leaders wherever you see blank fields.

Two tracks, one standard

	Level 1: CXE Practitioner (Agent track)	Level 2: CXE Leader (Leader track)
Who	Frontline agents / customer service specialists (CSS) in voice, chat, email, messaging, social and back office	Team leaders, supervisors, QA analysts, trainers, workforce and operations managers
Your "customer"	The external customer	Your agents (internal customers) and, through them, the external customer
Modules	1 to 5 and 7	1 to 7 (all), with Module 6 as the core of the leader track
Theoretical exam	Assessment A, pass mark 80%	Assessment B, pass mark 85%
Practical exam	Assessment C: role plays + live interactions, 85% and zero critical errors	Assessment D: role plays with agents + live coaching and huddle, 85% and zero critical errors
Re-verification	Annual (aligned with COPC CX Standard R8.0, Item 3.3)	Annual, plus quarterly calibration



Icons and boxes you will see

Box	Meaning
Blue box	Key idea or learning objectives
Orange header	Activity: individual, pairs or group practice
Green box	Updated 2024 to 2026 evidence with its source
Purple box	Leader lens: how a leader applies the same skill with agents
Red box	Watch out: common mistakes and critical errors

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Program overview and agenda

The program has seven modules. The agent track runs in two days (about 14 hours). The leader track adds a third day for Module 6 and the leader practical assessment. Times are guides; facilitators can adapt them.

Day	Block	Module / content	Track
1	08:30-10:30	Module 1: Introduction to Customer Experience Engineering	All
1	10:45-13:00	Module 2: What I Hear (Skill 1 Active Listening, Skill 2 Purposeful Small Talk)	All
1	14:00-17:30	Module 3: How I Respond (Skill 3 Positive Language, Skill 4 Advocacy, Skill 5 Alternative Positioning)	All
2	08:30-11:00	Module 4: Develop and Maintain Self-Awareness (Skills 6 and 7)	All
2	11:15-13:00	Module 5: Experience Engineering in the AI era (hybrid journeys, digital channels)	All
2	14:00-16:00	Module 7: Topic facilitation activity, summary, first three steps	All
2	16:15-17:30	Assessment A (agents) / Assessment B (leaders): theoretical	All
3	08:30-13:00	Module 6: Leading by Example (the leader track)	Leaders
3	14:00-17:30	Assessment D Part 1 (leader role plays)	Leaders
+2 to 4 wks	On the floor	Assessment C Part 2 (agents) and D Part 2 (leaders): live observations	All

Meet ACME Customer Care Center (fictitious)

Every example in this manual uses the same fictitious operation, so you can follow one story from start to finish.

Item	ACME Customer Care Center	Your organization
Lines of business	Telecom and home internet, retail banking cards, e-commerce orders, event tickets, healthcare appointment scheduling	_____
Channels	Voice, chat, email, WhatsApp-style messaging, AI virtual assistant with human handoff	_____
Size	240 agents, 16 team leaders, 4 operations managers, 8 QA analysts, 3 trainers	_____
Key metrics	CSAT and DSAT, Customer Effort Score (CES), FCR, repeat contacts, transfers, AHT, critical error accuracy, attrition, agent eNPS	_____
People in the stories	Agents: Luis, Ana, Kenji, Fatima. Team leader: Dana. Ops manager: Marco. QA analyst: Priya	_____

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1 Introduction to Customer Experience Engineering

Why reducing customer effort is the goal, and why being nice is not enough

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Explain why experience engineering is a critical frontline skill in 2026
- Describe the two components of customer effort and who controls each
- Distinguish traditional soft skills from experience engineering
- Name the seven skills of the framework and how they benefit you and your scorecard

1.1 An effective and emerging frontline skill

As service organizations work to improve the customer experience and earn loyalty, the skills that matter most are the ones aimed directly at that goal. **Customer Experience Engineering** is a strategy to **actively guide interactions** and **reduce customer effort**. With it you will learn to:

Keep control	Anticipate	Show you are on their side	Own your work
Guide each conversation with purpose instead of reacting to it	Get ahead of the customer's needs and of the next issue before it happens	Demonstrate a clear willingness to help, every time	Focus on what you can control and gain autonomy over how you handle each contact

1.2 Why it matters more than ever

Organizations that want to grow must **keep** the customers they already have, and the most reliable way to do that is to engineer better experiences. Three trends make this urgent in 2024 to 2026:

- **Simple issues are moving to self-service and AI, so humans get the hard ones.** Only 14% of service issues are fully resolved in self-service, and even among very simple issues only 36% are (Gartner, Aug 2024). When a customer reaches you, they have often already tried and failed, so their effort and emotion are higher.
- **Customers still want a human who helps.** 64% of customers would prefer companies not use AI for service, and 53% would consider switching to a competitor over it; the number one concern is difficulty reaching a person (Gartner, Jul 2024).
- **Leaders are redesigning, not removing, the human role.** 91% of service leaders feel pressure to implement AI in 2026, yet only 20% report AI-driven headcount reductions, and 84% plan to add new skills to agent roles (Gartner, Dec 2025 and Feb 2026).

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14%

of service issues fully resolved in self-service

Gartner, Aug 2024 (n=5,728)

64%

of customers would prefer companies NOT use AI for service

Gartner, Jul 2024 (n=5,728)

+34 pts

satisfaction when customers are TOLD they are talking to AI

COPC Inc., Jan 2026 (6 countries)

-70 pts

possible NPS drop when AI fails to resolve

COPC Inc., Jan 2026

49%

of repeat calls caused by the ORGANIZATION (38% agent, 13% customer)

SQM Group, Feb 2025

22%

of managers globally are engaged (down 9 pts since 2022)

Gallup State of the Global Workplace, 2026 report

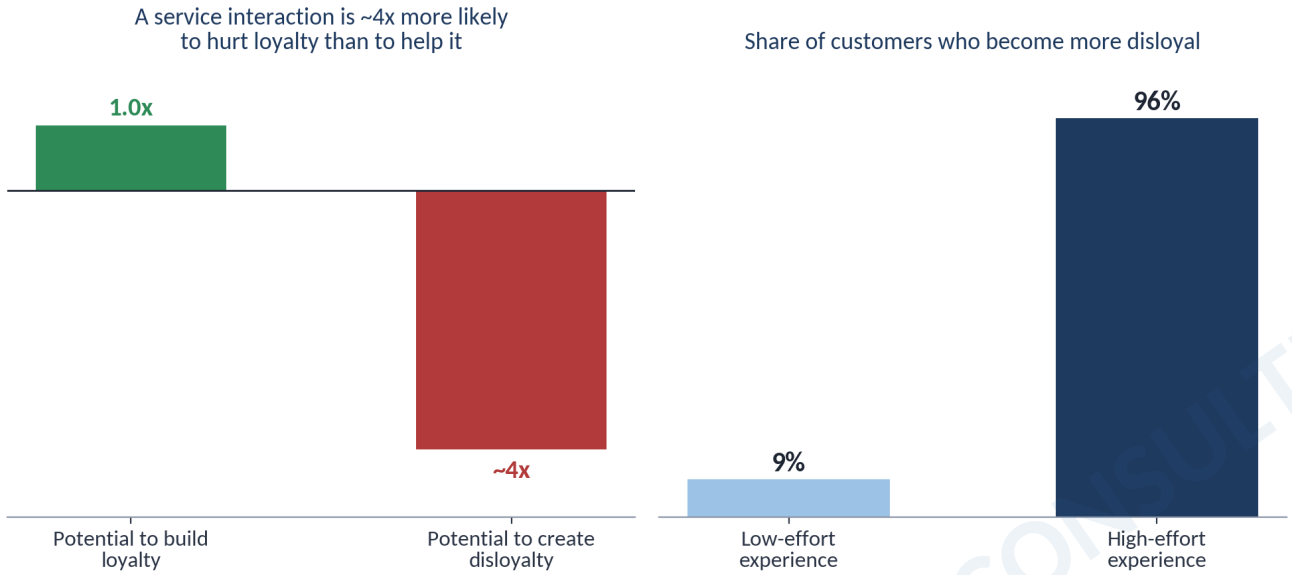
Updated evidence (2024-2026)

The human interaction is now the moment of truth for the most complex, most emotional problems. That is exactly where experience engineering has the highest return. Sources and verification links are in the Evidence and Sources Pack (document CXE-07).

1.3 Reducing customer effort: a goal with great value

Research by CEB (now part of Gartner) with more than 54,000 customers found that a service interaction is roughly **four times more likely to make a customer disloyal than loyal**. Your biggest opportunity is not to delight, but to **avoid creating disloyalty**, and the lever is effort: 96% of customers who had a high-effort experience became more disloyal, versus 9% after a low-effort one.

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Source: CEB (now Gartner) Customer Loyalty Survey, n = 54,166; reported in Dixon, Toman & DeLisi, The Effortless Experience (2013). Still cited by Gartner as the effort-loyalty baseline.

Is this still true? (2026 check)

Yes. Newer studies point the same way. Qualtrics XM Institute (Q3 2025, 20,000+ consumers, 14 countries) estimates US$3 trillion in global sales at risk from bad experiences in 2026; 47% of bad experiences lead customers to cut spending, and **Mexico has the highest share of spending at risk (8%)** of the countries studied. SQM Group (Feb 2025) finds that every 1-point gain in first call resolution raises interaction NPS by 1.4 points.

ACTIVITY **Effort in my own life**

Purpose	Time	Materials
Connect effort to loyalty from your own experience as a customer	7 min	Pen, this page

1. Write two sentences about a time a company made you work too hard as a customer (a bank, airline, phone company, government office).
2. Write how your own team or organization might unintentionally make customers work harder than necessary.
3. Share one example with the person next to you. Did the effort change what you did next as a customer?

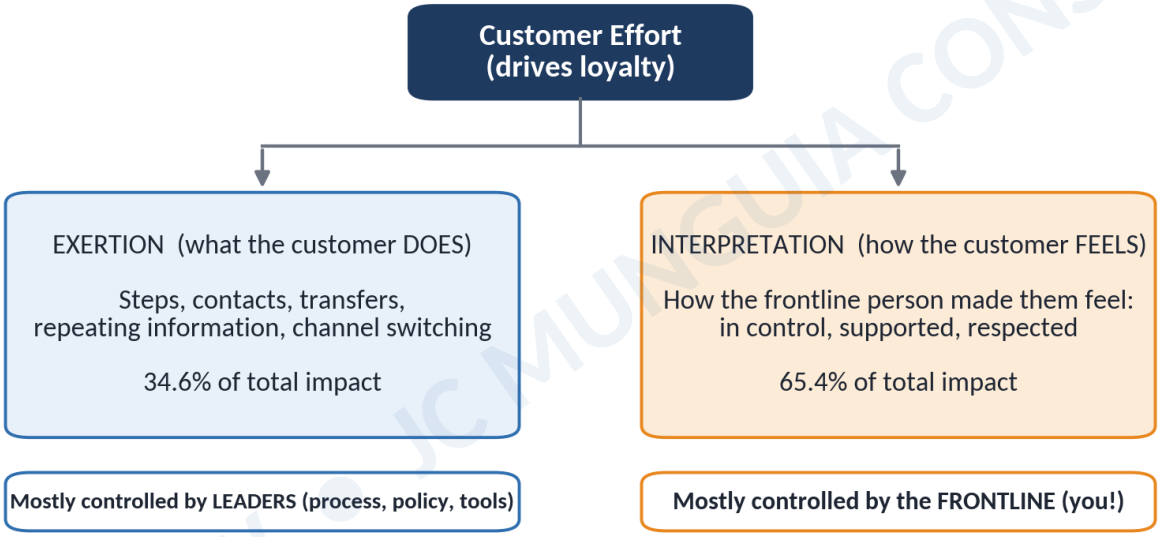
My high-effort experience as a customer:

How we may unintentionally create effort for our customers:

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1.4 What "effort" really means

Customer effort has two parts. **Exertion** is what the customer has to *do*: steps, contacts, transfers, repeating information, switching channels. **Interpretation** is how the customer *feels* about it: whether the frontline person made them feel supported and in control. In CEB's regression analysis (n = 4,589), interpretation carried **65.4%** of the impact on effort and exertion **34.6%**.



Examples of EXERTION (mostly controlled by leaders and process)	Examples of INTERPRETATION (mostly controlled by you)
• Number of contacts to solve one issue • Number of transfers • Repeating information already given (to the bot, to the IVR, to the last agent) • Being forced to switch channels ("please send us an email") • _____	• Flexibility shown by the frontline person • A visible willingness to help • Feeling that someone has taken control of the situation • Hearing what CAN be done, not only what cannot • _____

Leader lens

Exertion is 34.6% of the impact and it is largely designed by leaders: policies, IVR menus, tools, knowledge articles, transfer rules. The SQM 2025 benchmark finds the organization, not the agent, causes 49% of repeat calls. Leaders who only coach agents miss half the problem. See Module 6.

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1.5 It goes beyond being nice

In the same CEB research, several classic soft skills showed **no measurable effect** on reducing effort, and two had only a marginal effect. Customers expect courtesy; it does not, by itself, reduce the work they must do or change how they interpret it.

NO measurable effect on effort

- Showed concern
- Was non-scripted
- Understood the customer
- Listened well

MARGINAL effect (< 5%)

- Communicated clearly
- Demonstrated confidence

Being nice is the entry ticket, not the differentiator.

Discussion: Why do you think being nice is not enough? Where have you seen a very polite agent still leave you with all the work?

1.6 Traditional soft skills vs. experience engineering

Traditional soft skills	Customer Experience Engineering
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]

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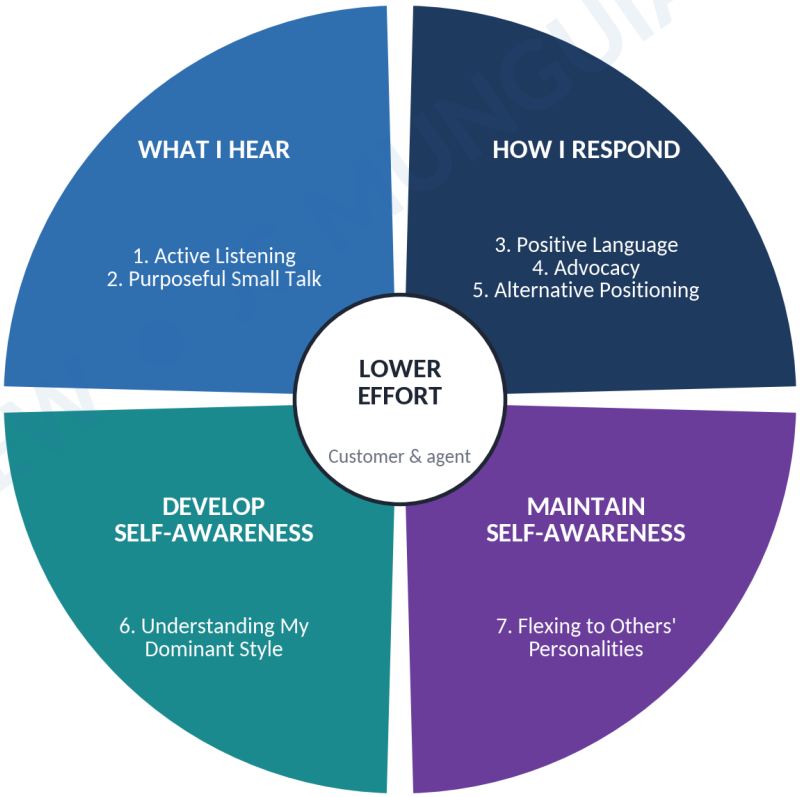
1.7 Relationship focus vs. outcome focus

Relationship focus	Outcome focus (experience engineering)
[illegible]	[illegible]

[illegible]

1.8 The framework: strategy and seven skills

[illegible]



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Part	Skills	What it does
What I hear		
How I respond		
Develop self-awareness		
Maintain self-awareness		

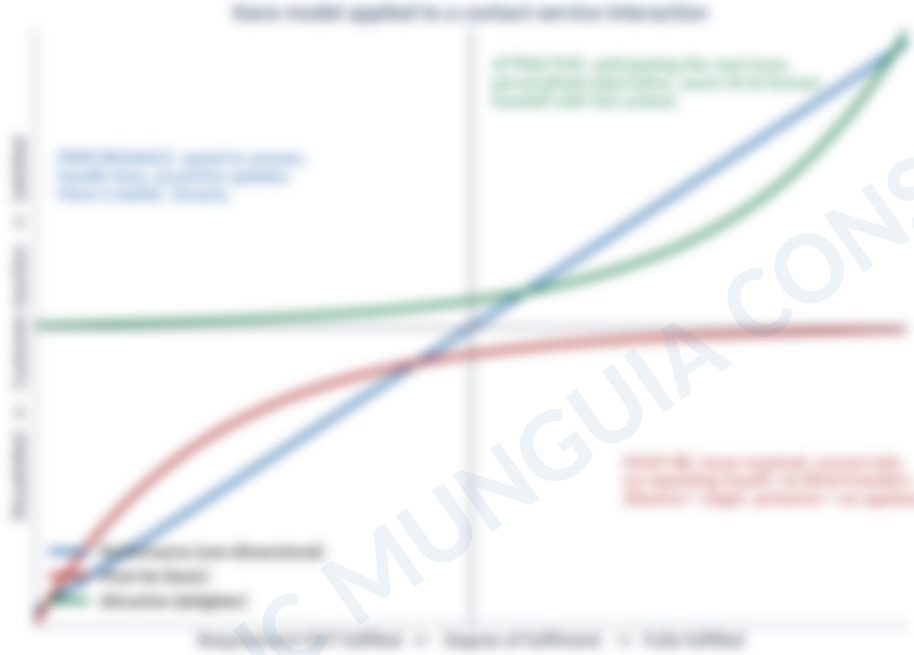
1.9 How does this benefit me?

Day-to-day benefit	What changes

Scorecard metric	Expected effect

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1.10 Where effort sits in the Kano model



Kano category	Contact-center examples	What to do
Must-be (basic)		
Performance		
Attractive (delighter)		
Indifferent		
Reverse		

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Module 1 review

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2 What I Hear

Skill 1 Active Listening and Skill 2 Purposeful Small Talk: getting the right information

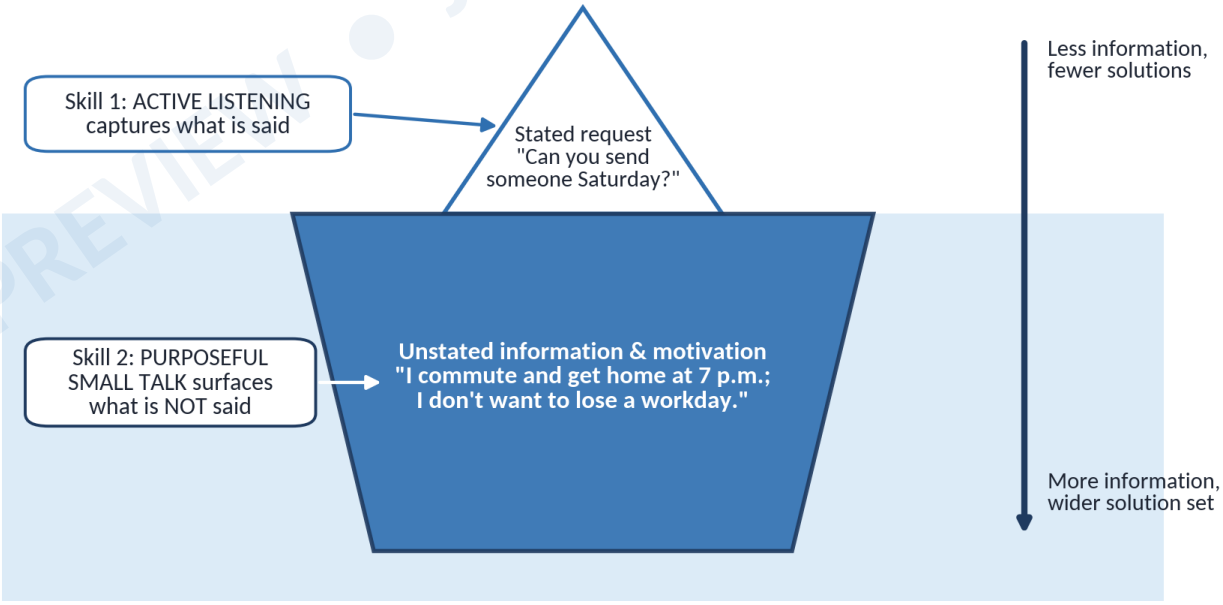
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Goal of this part of the framework

Collect all the information you need from the customer to offer the best possible solution. **Active listening** uses what the customer volunteers. **Purposeful small talk** uncovers the key information they did not volunteer.



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Skill 1: Active listening

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Identify the components of active listening
- Use active listening in customer cases and daily interactions, including chat and email (active reading)

[illegible]

Four qualities of active listeners

ATTENTION	OBJECTIVITY	PATIENCE	EMPATHY
Stay engaged and focused on what the customer is saying.	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]

Keeping your attention: four moves

Move	Confirm	Clarify	Paraphrase	Summarize
Examples	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Purpose	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Chat / email version	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]

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Warning signs that you are NOT listening actively

1. [illegible]
2. [illegible]
3. [illegible]
4. [illegible]

[illegible]

ACTIVITY **Four qualities and low effort**

[illegible]

ACTIVITY **Practicing active listening (pairs)**

[illegible]

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Skill 2: Purposeful small talk

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Explain what purposeful small talk is and how it helps you
- Recognize opportunities for small talk and ask questions at the right level

[redacted]

Asking questions at the right level



Open- vs. closed-ended questions

Open-ended questions	Closed-ended questions
[redacted]	[redacted]

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What it looks like in action (ACME Telecom)

Speaker	Words	Agent's objective
Agent (Luis)	[illegible]	
Customer	[illegible]	
Agent (Luis)	[illegible]	[illegible]
Customer	[illegible]	[illegible]

ACTIVITY **Asking questions to uncover customer information**

[illegible]

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Scenario	My question(s)	Information I could uncover
[illegible]		
[illegible]		
[illegible]		
[illegible]		
[illegible]		
[illegible]		

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3 How I Respond

Skill 3 Positive Language, Skill 4 Advocacy, Skill 5 Alternative Positioning: guiding the conversation

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Goal of this part of the framework

Guide the conversation to present solutions in the best possible light.
Positive language: choose your words carefully to minimize customer effort.
Advocacy: champion the customer's issue and own its resolution.
Alternative positioning: match the customer's needs and motivations with the solutions available.

Skill 3: Positive language

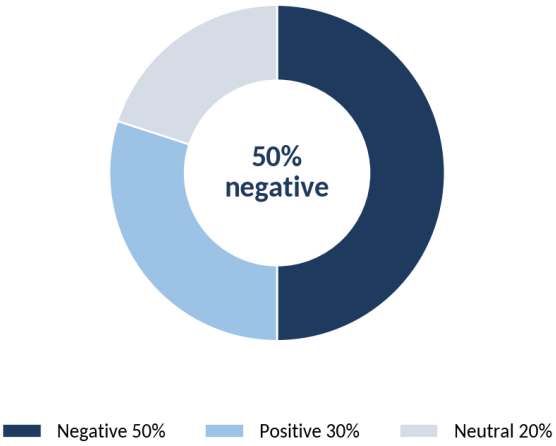
By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Tell positive from negative language and describe the effect of each on the experience
- Recognize and avoid common words and phrases that create customer effort

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It's not just you, it's everyone

Emotion words in everyday vocabulary



Words that silently raise effort



What negative language leads to

Effect	Evidence
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]

Small changes, big effects

Rep response A: negative language	Rep response B: positive language
[illegible]	[illegible]

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Updated evidence: what newer research adds

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Say this, not that

From negative...	...to positive
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]

ACTIVITY	Say this, not that: my own phrases

[illegible]

Negative words and phrases I use	Positive, concrete translation

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Skill 4: Advocacy

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Understand and practice advocacy as a technique to reduce customer effort

[illegible]

Response A (no advocacy)	Response B (experience engineering)	What the rep did
"It's **really difficult** to tell what's happening over the phone. **You should just** take it to one of our certified repair shops and have it looked at."	[illegible]	[illegible]

Leader lens

[illegible]

ACTIVITY	Positive language and advocacy

[illegible]

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Skill 5: Alternative positioning

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Use the information gathered during the conversation to position tailored solutions when the first option is not available



Principle	How

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Decision tree: small talk and alternative positioning



Use small talk with customers who are...	Avoid it with customers who are...
[illegible]	[illegible]

What do you do when "no" is the only answer?

[illegible]

DO	DON'T
[illegible]	[illegible]

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Revisiting the conversation: all five skills together

Speaker	Words	Skill in use
Customer	[illegible]	[illegible]
Agent (Luis)	[illegible]	[illegible]
Customer	[illegible]	[illegible]
Agent (Luis)	[illegible]	[illegible]

ACTIVITY **Role plays: responding with positive language**

[illegible]

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4 Develop and Maintain Self-Awareness

Skill 6 Understanding My Dominant Personality Style and Skill 7 Flexing to Others' Personalities

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Goal of this part of the framework

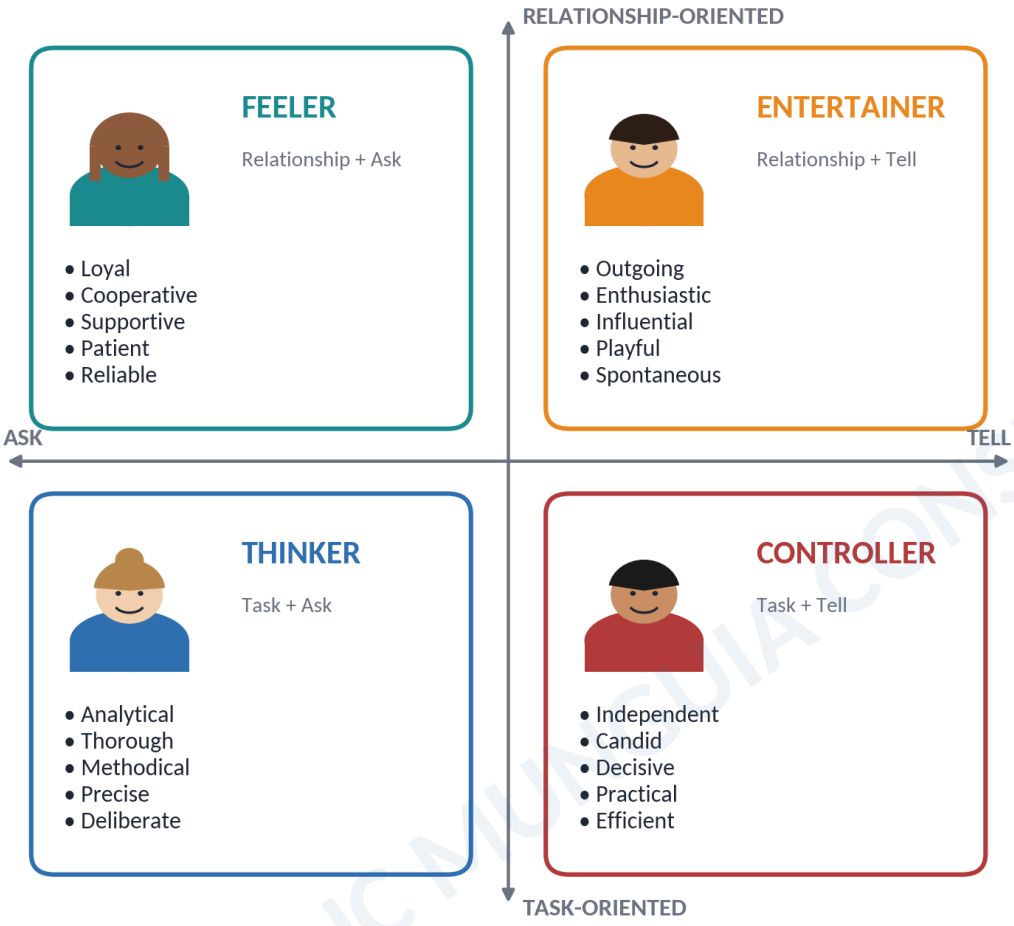
Keep control of your own actions in stressful situations without burning out. To manage customer interactions, you first have to manage yourself. Knowing your style is the foundation that lets you keep listening, making purposeful small talk, using positive language, advocating and positioning solutions, even under stress.

Skill 6: Understanding my dominant personality style

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Identify your personality style and how it is uniquely suited to serving customers
- Recognize your style's stress response and choose ways to cope with and manage stress

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Customer service by personality style

Style	Strengths	Keep in mind
Feeler		
Entertainer		
Thinker		
Controller		

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ACTIVITY	How my style fits experience engineering

[illegible]

Skill	My rating (1-5)	One thing I will do to strengthen it
1 Active listening		
2 Purposeful small talk		
3 Positive language		
4 Advocacy		
5 Positioning solutions		

How each style reacts to stress

[illegible]

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Style	Stress response	Early warning signs (write your own)	Recovery tactic
Feeler			
Entertainer			
Thinker			
Controller			

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Skill 7: Flexing to others' personalities

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Identify your customers' personality styles
- Adapt your approach to interact effectively with each style



Style	They sound like	Traits	Remember to
Feeler (empathy-oriented)			
Entertainer (social-oriented)			
Thinker (process-oriented)			
Controller (results-oriented)			

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Flexing guide: if you are... and they are...

You are ↓ / They are →	Controller	Thinker	Entertainer	Feeler
Controller				
Thinker				
Entertainer				
Feeler				

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ACTIVITY **Role plays: personality-based communication**

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5 Experience Engineering in the AI Era

Applying the seven skills in hybrid (AI + human) journeys and digital channels

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By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Explain how AI and self-service change what reaches the human agent
- Handle a customer who arrives after a failed bot or self-service attempt without adding effort
- Apply the seven skills in chat, email and messaging, and when using AI agent-assist tools

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5.1 What the 2025-2026 data says

Finding	What it means for you	Source (date)
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]

Engineering the hybrid (AI + human) journey



Agent opening after a failed bot: "I can see you already tried the assistant and gave us your account and the error code. I've got it here, so you won't need to repeat anything."

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5.2 The seven skills after a failed bot

Skill	What to do in the first 60 seconds
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]

5.3 Digital-channel adaptations

Channel	Do	Avoid
Chat / messaging	[illegible]	[illegible]
Email	[illegible]	[illegible]
Agent-assist / GenAI drafts	[illegible]	[illegible]
Social / public	[illegible]	[illegible]

Watch out: critical errors in the AI era

[illegible]

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6 Leading by Example (Leader Track)

Your customers are your agents: using the same standard to build a low-effort culture

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By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Apply the seven skills with agents, who are the leader's internal customers
- Run COPC R8.0-aligned monitoring, coaching and calibration that reinforce experience engineering
- Measure and reduce both customer effort and agent (CSS) effort
- Lead team rituals that make low effort the way the team works

6.1 The parallel process

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The parallel process: how leaders treat agents is how agents treat customers



Employee effort (CSS effort) is an explicit input in COPC CX Standard R8.0, Item 3.9 (Optimizing Service Journeys).

Updated evidence (2026)

[redacted]

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6.2 The seven skills, leader version

Skill	With customers (agent)	With agents (leader)	Leader example (ACME, Dana)
1 Active listening			
2 Purposeful small talk			
3 Positive language			
4 Advocacy			
5 Alternative positioning			
6 Self-awareness			
7 Flexing			

6.3 The Experience-Engineered Coaching Conversation (5 steps)

Step	What the leader does	Skills	Sample words
1. Open and listen			
2. Reinforce what worked			
3. Focus on one opportunity			
4. Remove obstacles			
5. Commit and follow up			

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6.4 Monitoring, calibration and coaching aligned with COPC R8.0



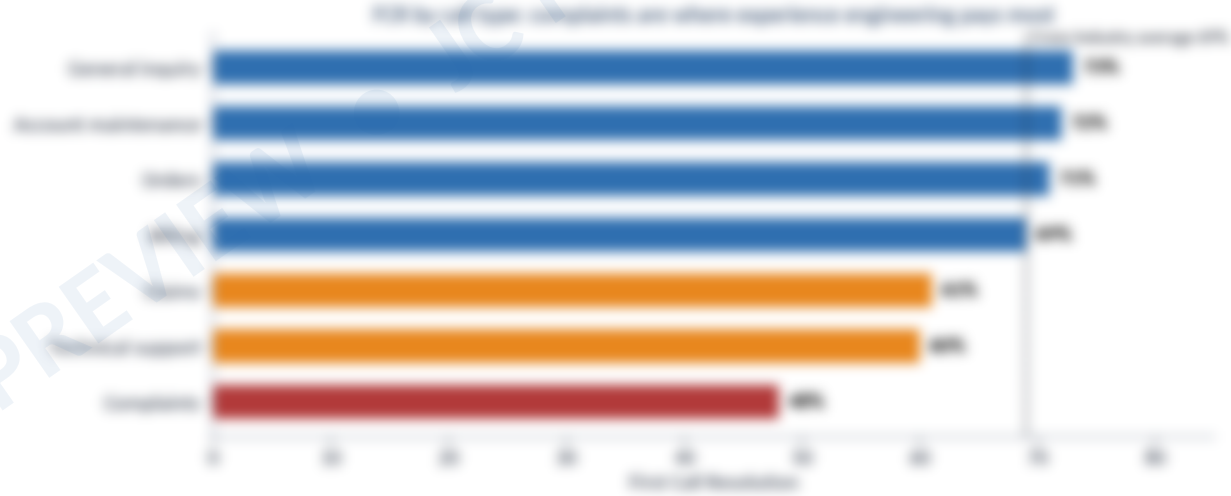
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Requirement (summary)	COPC R8.0 item	How CXE applies it
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]

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6.5 Measuring effort: the leader's dashboard

Metric	Definition	Why it matters	Typical direction
Customer Effort Score (CES)			
First Contact Resolution (FCR)			
Repeat contact rate (7 days)			
Transfer rate			
CSAT top box and DSAT			
Customer critical error accuracy			
Agent effort / eNPS			



Worked example: calculating CES and the value of FCR

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6.6 Building the culture: team rituals

Ritual	Frequency	How it works
Effort huddle	[illegible]	[illegible]
Effort hunt	[illegible]	[illegible]
Golden calls	[illegible]	[illegible]
Leader self-check	[illegible]	[illegible]
Kano backlog	[illegible]	[illegible]

Watch out: leader behaviors that destroy the culture

[illegible]

ACTIVITY Leader practice: flip the scenario

[illegible]

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7 Topic Facilitation, Summary and Next Steps

Teach it back, commit to it, and put it to work tomorrow

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ACTIVITY	Topic facilitation (team practice)

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Summary

[illegible]

My first three steps

[illegible]

30-60-90 day plan

Horizon	My goal	How I'll measure it	Who will support me
30 days			
60 days			
90 days			

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Appendix A. Phrasebook: say this, not that

Situation	Avoid	Say instead
Opening after a failed bot	[illegible]	[illegible]
Can't do it now	[illegible]	[illegible]
Out of stock	[illegible]	[illegible]
Transfer	[illegible]	[illegible]
Policy	[illegible]	[illegible]
Customer error	[illegible]	[illegible]
Waiting	[illegible]	[illegible]
Uncertain outcome	[illegible]	[illegible]
Complaint	[illegible]	[illegible]
Closing	[illegible]	[illegible]
Leader to agent: feedback	[illegible]	[illegible]
Leader to agent: can't grant a request	[illegible]	[illegible]

Appendix B. Main contact drivers and KPIs

[illegible]

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Contact driver (example)	Effort signal	Example KPI	Owner
Billing questions / disputes	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Order status / delivery	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Technical support	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Account access / passwords	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Complaints	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Sales / retention (if applicable)	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]

Appendix C. Glossary

Term	Meaning
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]

Appendix D. Program documents and key references

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Code	Document
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]
[illegible]	[illegible]

[illegible]

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Get the full certification program

You have seen the map. The full edition gives your team the whole journey:

- The complete 49-page Participant Manual: seven skills, AI-era journeys, and the Leader Track (leading by example)
- Assessment A and B: theoretical exams for agents and leaders
- Assessment C and D: practical certification with role plays and live interactions, COPC R8.0-aligned scorecards
- Facilitator Guide with answer keys, actor briefs and evaluator calibration
- Evidence and Sources Pack with 2024-2026 data and verification links
- Implementation support: tailoring to your operation, train-the-trainer, and measurement of effort (CES, FCR, repeat contacts)

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